On being quizzed on his felicity in three languages, Neelakantan is candid. "I am not a trilingual writer, I am a Malayalam writer who thinks and writes in Malayalam in my mind," he says. "On paper or computer, I may write in English, Malayalam or Hindi. But the original story and even words and sentence structure always form in my mind in Malayalam. It is only during editing that I change the syntax, style and words to suit the intended language of use."

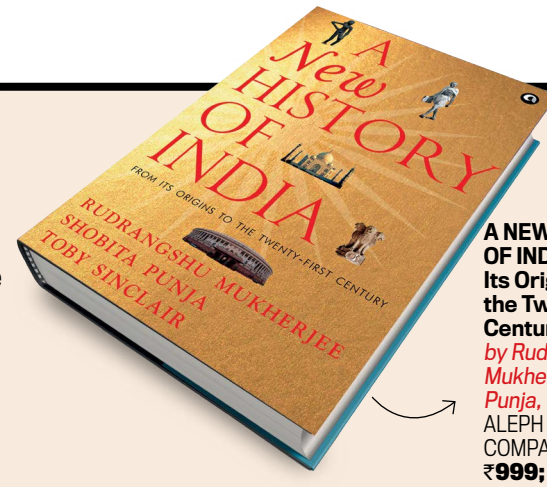
Neelakantan has a packed calendar in the coming months. He is working on a two-part film in multiple languages with Rakeysh Omprakash Mehra. There is a business thriller coming up with Rohan Sippy on a major OTT platform. There's a novel set in ancient Tamilakam to be published by Penguin next year. A few children's books, one non-fiction and two audio originals are awaiting release. "Besides this, work is on for a major South Indian film with a stellar cast," says Neelakantan. A truly epic oeuvre. ■

Amit Dixit

BOOKS

LONG STORY SHORT

A new volume by distinguished scholars tries to trace the entire span of Indian history from its prehistoric beginnings right up to 1992



A NEW HISTORY OF INDIA: From Its Origins to the Twenty-first Century
by Rudrangshu Mukherjee, Shobita Punja, Toby Sinclair
ALEPH BOOK COMPANY
₹999; 455 pages

A history of India by a distinguished trio of scholars, this book covers the entire span of India's chronological past from its prehistoric beginnings to 1992, when the Babri Masjid was demolished. The subsequent years under the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) are not tackled, but the authors note with alarm the growing majoritarianism and intolerance. The volume is attractively produced, the writing is accessible, the tone is moderate. Numerous photographs, mostly of monuments, are well-chosen. These tell a story of their own, which defy the indigenes-versus-invaders narrative.

On two historical contentious issues, the authors are firm and take the side of liberal scholarship. 'Aryans' are a language group, people who spoke this language migrated in waves (genetic research has proved this beyond doubt). Yes, invasions did happen in medieval India, and there were conversions to Islam, but there is little evidence of forced conversions. Accommodation, religious toleration, scepticism, dissent and camaraderie flourished, reflected in the rich strain of popular cultures.

If India was a cultural zone with a distinctive civilisational ethos, the book conveys it well. But the title promises something new. So, what is new in this book? While the larger narrative is the usual account of kings and dynasties, there are some interspersing chapters that attempt a longue durée. One such chapter is 'India and the World c.3000 BCE to 1800 CE'. The underlying theme in it is the dynamic connect of peninsular Indians to the wider world. Another valuable chapter is the conventionally titled 'The Influence of Islam', which certainly reflects the long tradition of sympathetic accounts written by Kshitimohan Sen, Tarachand, M. Mujeeb and B.N. Pandey, where the legacy of the Bhakti movement, which drew on heterodox and Sufi traditions, is highlighted.

'The Northeast up to the Coming of British Rule' is a compensatory gesture to a region rarely addressed in histories. This chapter gives little credence to the view that resistance to the expanding Mughals was an inclusive claim to belong to a putative heartland. 'Movements outside the Gandhian Fold, 1907-1947' looks at alternative models of nationhood, and it is only here that Jyotiba Phule and Bhimrao Ambedkar finally make an appearance. Significantly, 'Dalit' doesn't find place in the index.

By and large, the book plumps for the umbrella view of the nation first articulated by the Indian National Congress in the 19th century. For some reason, the authors don't engage with the latest scholarship and trends in Indian history-writing. The chapter on the 18th century is a disappointment and does not incorporate the exciting revisions on the nature of this tumultuous era. The possibilities offered by new research on India's long coastline, the complex monsoon ecologies, and the traditions of seafaring are not taken up. It has certainly weakened the claims of the Gangetic plains being the only locus of Indian civilisation. For this reason, the interpretations remain unexceptionable and the book lacks bite. ■

Partho Datta

Though **A New History of India** promises something new, it delivers a familiar summary of liberal scholarship